

bollards in front of the airport has already been in court. Bilal Abdullah, a 27-year-old Iraq-born doctor specialising in diabetes, was charged recently in London with conspiracy to cause explosions. He will not be put on trial for some time.

Just hours earlier, Kafeel had called his mother Dr Zakia Ahmed at their sprawling home in Banashankari, Bangalore, and asked her to pray for the success of an important project which concerned "global warming". She, of course, had no idea it was one that meant ploughing a firebomb into passengers arriving into Scotland's busiest airport. The details of the conspiracy are being uncovered as detectives and intelligence agents put together the story behind one of the most spectacular, if amateurish, terrorist attacks in the UK in many years.

There are now seven men and one woman linked to what has come to be known as "the doctors' plot". In fact, not all concerned were trained medical staff, but the name has stuck. It adequately communicates the 'small group dynamics' that bound the conspiracy together. Four clear links have emerged between its members: three suspects—Kafeel, Sabeel and Haneef—are from the same family; two were members of the Tablighi Jamaat, the avowedly non-violent Muslim missionary group; three lived in the British university city of Cambridge in recent years and almost certainly prayed at the same mosque; and all seven had worked at one time or another for the British National Health Service.

There was little reason to think the lanky, five-foot-seven-inch tall youth, now lying on the burns unit bed, could be the lynchpin of a failed mass-casualty attack. In fact, Kafeel seemed marked out to become a brilliant aeronautical engineer who would build aircraft that would jet in and out of Glasgow. He was the eldest son of Dr Maqbool and Dr Zakia Ahmed, medical practitioners who had moved from Saudi Arabia, where the children were schooled, to Bangalore in 1994. The father was involved with Jamaat-e-Islami and had a great influence on the boys. Although his mother is from Pakistan, Maqbool himself had lived in

Nagenahalli in Karnataka for 40 years before moving to West Asia for work. The family lived in Iran from 1979 to 1983 and in Saudi Arabia for 10 years before heading to Bangalore, where the children were born—Zakia travelled to India each time to deliver Kafeel, Sabeel and Sadia Kauser.

Kafeel was the brightest of the three. He ranked 5,711 in the Common Entrance Test in 1996 and secured admission to the University BDT (UBDT) College of Engineering at Devangere, a textile town 280 km north of Bangalore. He was shy, reserved and kept to himself. An exceptional student who stood fifth in the university seven years ago having scored 87.15 per cent, Kafeel was extremely sensitive.

"He was ragged in his first semester and was moved to tears even at the most simple questions like who he was and where he came from," says Dr K.V. Arun, Kafeel's senior by two years, and now a faculty member in the state's Industrial Production Department. He never sought or received a scholarship though he consistently scored between 80 and 90 per cent. "He never went out of his way to approach anyone, unless it was something to do with studies. He was, however, friendly in the sense that if someone went to him for something, he always helped," says Keshav Thakuria, 29, a student from Assam who sat next to Kafeel in class.

A loner, Kafeel chose to live as a paying guest in the home of Sher Ali Khan in a colony adjacent to the college, instead of the more usual college hostel, for the duration of his four-year course. He never hung out with his classmates. In the four years that Kafeel studied at UBDT, he never went out for a movie or a meal with his friends—he backed out of these outings on the pretext of visiting his parents in Bangalore. He was hardly ever spotted at the college canteen—a favourite student hangout, never participated in extracurricular activities, and posed for a picture only once, in a forum in the department of mechanical engineering. No one could fathom what was on his mind.

"He didn't go out of his way to be friendly or to participate in any of the college activities; everyone seems to remember him only because he was brilliant in studies," says Dr Abdul Budan,

MOHAMMED HANEEF: The

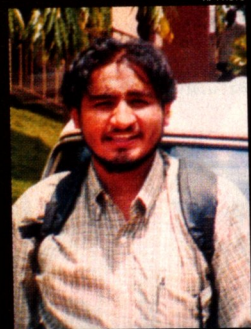
THE AUSSIE CONNECTION

■ Born in 1981. Son of a school teacher from Mangalore. School topper, studies at Bangalore's Ambedkar Medical College with his second cousin Sabeel Ahmed. Passes out in 2002.

■ Takes up job in Halton Hospital in Cheshire. Moves to Brisbane, Australia, in 2006. In regular contact with Kafeel, Sabeel and other conspirators.

■ Arrested by Australian police before boarding flight to Bangalore on one-way ticket.

SABEEL AHMED: Brothe



WARNING SIGNAL Sabeel Ahmed at the Ambedkar Medical College (top right); the Jamia Hazrat Tippu Mosque (right) which the Ahmed brothers wanted to radicalise; (far right) their house 'Kauser'



head of the Department of Mechanical Engineering at UBDT.

The only time Kafeel drew closer to his classmates was during the project work towards the end of 1999. He was part of a team of six students who had to prepare a project in their seventh semester, important not only for their marks but also to equip them with entrepreneurial and creative skills for the